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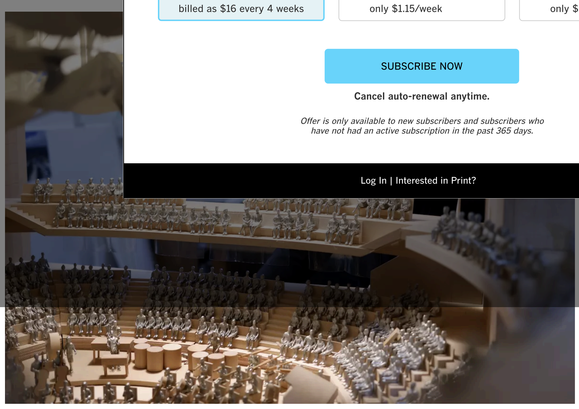
Frank Gehry's vision for a world-class Grand Avenue cultural district remains largely incomplete despite the recent opening of The Grand and Colburn Center concert hall. Before the 2028 Olympics, improvements to Disney Concert Hall, artist housing, and pedestrian access could finally activate this downtown arts corridor. A fully realized arts district could position Los Angeles as a major international cultural destination rivaling established festivals like Salzburg.



Architect Frank Gehry peers into a model of his design for the expansion of the Colburn School, a private performing arts school in downtown Los Angeles. It'll be the third Gehry-designed building on Bunker Hill. (Christina House / Los Angeles Times)

By Mark Swed
Classical Music Critic | Follow

March 20, 2026 3 AM PT

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Spring is the season of creation, a time of renewal and new beginnings. In Los Angeles, alas, we were, last spring, a city of cinders. It was a time to mourn.

A hard year followed with floods, ICE, AI, etc., menacing our native optimism. Making matters worse, in December we lost L.A.'s grand visionary vizier, the architect who time and again built us out of civic funk and transformed L.A., inspiring the city he so loved to look good, feel good and do good.

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Mark Swed

Mark Swed has been the classical music critic of the Los Angeles Times since 1996.

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